

Unit 4B

Grammar: Question Forms (cont.) - Indirect Questions

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Indirect Questions

A **direct question** is when you question someone, or a group of people directly, for example:

1. *“Is this your wallet?” (directly to someone)*
2. *“Who owns the car that’s parked over there?” (directly to a group of people)*

But an **indirect** question is when you are asking for information indirectly from someone, or a group of people, for example:

1. *“**Do you know** who’s wallet this is?” (now the question is do you know...)*
2. *“**Does anyone know** who owns the car that’s parked over there? (now the question is does anyone know...?)”*

But why do we need to use indirect questions?

Why can't we just use a direct question? For example, if you are speaking to someone in the street:

“Where is the bus station?”

Because the above question **is considered rude!** To ask direct questions **to people you don't know** in general, is considered rude in English speaking culture! **The polite way to ask** is as follows:

*“Excuse me, **could you** (please) **tell me** where the bus station is?”*

*You can also use indirect questions with people you know. It's still polite.

Grammar: Question Forms (cont.)

5. With **indirect questions**, when we ask for information using the following phrases, **the word order is inverted** (“is” is moved to the end of the phrase, after the **object**):

- *Can/could you tell me...?*
- *Do you know...*
- *I wonder...*
- *I want to know...*
- *Does anyone know...*

**There are more indirect question phrases*

(direct): Where **is** the closest pharmacy?

(indirect): **Does anyone know** where the closest pharmacy **is**?



(direct): This pie is amazing! What **is** Anna's secret?

(indirect): This pie is amazing! **I wonder** what Anna's secret **is**.



TAKE NOTE:

I wonder is not followed by a question mark because technically, it is not a question. (although the structure is the same, but the question is within your head, to yourself)

6. When we have direct questions with **do/does/did**, and we want to transform them into indirect question using the phrases mentioned before, we **eliminate** the **do/does/did**.

Why did Rachel reject that offer? The salary was great!

I wonder why Rachel rejected that offer. The salary was great!

NOT

I wonder why ~~did~~ Rachel reject that offer. The salary was great! ❌

- Can/could you tell me...?
- Do you know...
- I wonder...
- I want to know...
- Does anyone know...

How did Dave fix this computer yesterday?

Does anyone know how Dave fixed this computer yesterday?

NOT

Does anyone know how ~~did~~ Dave fix this computer yesterday? ❌

TAKE NOTE:

When you eliminate **did** when forming the indirect question, your main verb **must be in the past simple**.

7. When there **isn't** a question word in the direct question, we **have to** use **if** or **whether** in the indirect question form:

(direct): Did anybody see you leaving your house?

(indirect): Do you know **if** anybody saw you leaving your house?

Do you know **whether** anybody saw you leaving your house?

(direct): Can you help Mike move this sofa?

(indirect): Do you know **if** someone can help Mike move this sofa?

Do you know **whether** someone can help Mike move this sofa?

BE CAREFUL:

Why is James leaving so early?

Can someone tell me why James is leaving so early?

NOT

Can someone tell me ~~whether~~ James is leaving so early? **X**

• **Questions words:**

- who
- when
- where
- why
- what
- which
- how

*They are sometimes called -wh words

***CAUTION:** Do/does/can/have etc. are **NOT question words!** (they are auxiliary verbs)

TAKE NOTE:

Don't confuse **whether** with **weather!**

Task 4.2

Transform the following direct questions into their indirect forms:

1. Where is the closest ATM? (*Automatic Teller Machine*)

Could you tell me _____

2. Did Greg receive your postcard?

Do you know _____

3. Is Larry meeting us in Paris?

I wonder _____

4. How far is your house from the city centre?

Have you any idea _____

5. What did the butler say when you gave him that tip?

I would like to know _____

6. Will they offer special assistance to embark?

Do you think _____

7. Did William find his phone in the end?

Does anyone know _____

8. Has she ever been to Iceland?

Does he know _____

9. Why are they digging holes in the road outside my house?

Can anyone tell me _____

10. Can she also play the guitar?

I wonder _____

Task 4.2

Transform the following direct questions into their indirect forms:

1. Where is the closest ATM? (*Automatic Teller Machine*)

Could you tell me where the closest ATM is?

2. Did Greg receive your postcard?

Do you know if/whether Greg received your postcard?

3. Is Larry meeting us in Paris?

I wonder if/whether Larry's meeting us in Paris.

4. How far is your house from the city centre?

Have you any idea how far your house is from the city centre?

5. What did the butler say when you gave him that tip?

I would like to know what the butler said when you gave him that tip?

6. Will they offer special assistance to embark?

Do you think (that) they will offer special assistance to embark?

7. Did William find his phone in the end?

Does anyone know if/whether William found his phone?

8. Has she ever been to Iceland?

Does he know if/whether she's ever been to Iceland?

9. Why are they digging holes in the road outside my house?

Can anyone tell me why they're digging holes in the road outside my house?

10. Can she also play the guitar?

I wonder if/whether she can also play the guitar?

Part 2

You will hear an interview with Elizabeth Holmes about her experience working in Africa. For questions **9 - 18**, complete the sentences.

Volunteering in Africa

Elizabeth worked for a

9 before she went to Africa.

Elizabeth first found out about working as a volunteer from a

10 she saw at the dentist's.

The course in London that Elizabeth attended was called

11

Elizabeth's job in Africa was to teach

12 how to market their goods.

On arrival in Africa, Elizabeth spent

13 doing a training course with other volunteers.

Elizabeth used a

14 to travel short distances in Africa.

Elizabeth feels that she got on best with

15 in the area of Africa where she lived.

Back in England, Elizabeth found that she was disturbed by the

16 in the city.

At the moment, Elizabeth buys and sells

17 from Africa.

Nowadays, Elizabeth spends more time on her favourite pastime which is

18